9.5 Applying Cedar’s policy patterns

Cedar’s flexibility comes from its ability to express various authorization patterns and combine them within the same policy set. The ACME identity team uses three common patterns across the Customer Collaboration platform: discretionary permissions, membership permissions, and relationship permissions. By mixing these where appropriate, they can address nearly every business requirement without making policies overly complex.

9.5.1 Discretionary permissions

Discretionary permissions, often called DAC, let resource owners directly control who can access their resources. Most ReBAC models are discretionary. For example, at ACME, an owner can add employees to an `employee_readers_team` or customers to a `customer_readers_team` for a document. Once a principal joins one of these teams, the discretionary policy pattern enables them to view the document without changing the core policy set.

```
permit(
  principal is ACME::Customer,
  action == ACME::Action::"doc:view",
  resource is ACME::Document
)
when {
  principal in resource.customer_readers_team
};
```

Because team membership lives in the entity store, access updates happen instantly when someone is added or removed from a `reader's` team; there’s no need to change policies or redeploy services. This keeps policies simple and stable while allowing detailed, document-specific control.